

FROM MAYHEM TO METHOD

Dricus du Plessis showcased a more disciplined, tactical approach to **outpoint** Kamaru Usman, proving his evolution as a middleweight title contender.

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Dricus du Plessis' return to the Octagon was defined not by his trademark chaos but by composure.

In the UFC Fight Night main event in Oklahoma City, the former middleweight champion secured a unanimous decision over former welterweight king Kamaru Usman, delivering one of the most disciplined performances of his UFC career. **The victory puts Du Plessis firmly back in the middleweight title picture while underlining the evolution of his game.**

Known for overwhelming opponents with awkward combinations and relentless pressure, the South African instead adopted a patient approach. He

worked behind a steady jab, mixed in calf kicks and forced Usman to react before unleashing heavier combinations. By refusing to chase an early finish, Du Plessis denied Usman the counter-wrestling opportunities that have long been central to his success.

Usman's wrestling never gained sustained momentum. Whenever the former champion looked to close the distance, Du Plessis framed effectively, circled away or landed the cleaner strikes in the clinch while maintaining excellent balance. On the feet, he varied his attacks between the body and head, disrupting Usman's rhythm and preventing him from establishing his jab. By the championship rounds, Du Plessis was dictating both range and tempo.

The co-main event also had major middleweight implications as Christian Leroy Duncan outpointed



Did you know?

Before undergoing corrective nasal surgery in early 2023, Du Plessis fought with a broken nose and a severely deviated septum that left his nasal airways nearly 80% blocked. Forced to rely largely on mouth breathing, he still compiled an undefeated UFC record before finally addressing the issue.

veteran Jared Cannonier. Duncan relied on movement, long-range kicks and sharp angles to stay clear of Cannonier's power, earning a composed decision victory and strengthening his credentials as a rising contender.

Elsewhere on the card, Chase Hooper continued his impressive lightweight run with a first-round rear-naked choke submission of Mitch Ramirez. Fatima Kline outclassed Tabatha Ricci over three rounds through superior striking volume and cage control, while Tommy McMillen produced a highlight-reel knockout of Alberto Montes to claim a Performance of the Night bonus. RJ Harris, Dione Barbosa and Felipe Franco also impressed with bonus-winning finishes on an action-packed night.

Statement victory: Du Plessis won a dominant five-round decision over Usman in what was the Fight of the Night at UFC Oklahoma City, with scorecards of 50-45, 49-46, and 49-46 in the South African's favour. GETTY IMAGES

